Olashile Agaba

Professor Dr. John Wetsch

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Chapter 2: Ethics Issues

This situation feels more than simple office politics. It presents a clear ethical issue because the boss is asking the IT manager to influence the committee into approving a proposal that was previously rejected, solely because of a personal friendship. This creates a conflict of interest, where personal relationships interfere with objective and fair decision-making. According to SpeakUp (2023), a conflict of interest occurs when personal connections compromise professional judgment. In this case, the integrity of the review process is at risk because decisions should be based on cost, organizational needs, and long-term goals, not personal relationships.

Favoritism like this can seriously harm an organization. Research shows that it weakens trust and reduces fairness in the workplace (Honest Values, 2023). When employees perceive bias, morale can decline, and confidence in leadership decisions can erode. Over time, this behavior also sets a poor precedent, weakening internal controls and accountability (Aristo Sourcing, 2022). Pushing for approval based on friendship rather than merit is unethical and damaging to the organization as a whole.

Professional codes of ethics reinforce this concern. The ACM Code of Ethics states that computing professionals must act with honesty, fairness, and integrity, even when facing pressure from colleagues or leadership (ACM, 2018). As committee chair, the IT manager has a responsibility to ensure the process remains ethical and transparent.

If I were in the IT manager's position, I would first speak with my supervisor to explain why personal bias cannot influence the decision. Any reconsideration of the proposal should be based on new, objective information, not personal relationships. If the pressure continued, documenting the situation and consulting HR or an ethics committee would be a responsible next step, as recommended by Pollack Peacebuilding Systems (2023). Resigning should be a last resort, since remaining in the role allows the manager to continue protecting ethical standards within the organization.

While some may argue that personal relationships should carry some weight, allowing them to influence formal decisions is risky and can lead to long-term consequences if left unaddressed.

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